

English Ladder

Student Workbook

Expressing Optimism or Pessimism in English

A polished self-study handout designed for print or tablet use. Read the concept, notice the pattern, and then complete the matching practice set on your own.



Grammar Concepts #08

Key Points

Practice with Example Sentences

Tips for Non-Native Speakers

Visual anchor

Use the concept poster to spotlight the main language pattern in **Expressing Optimism or Pessimism in English** and keep the explanation visible during practice and discussion.

ENGLISH LADDER

Concept #08 ► **Expressing Optimism/Pessimism**

We use different words and different verb styles when we are positive (optimistic) or negative (pessimistic).

WHICH TWIN...?

When I marry
Sarah, I will build
her a house!

(Close to 100% certainty)
When — marry— will

If I marry Sarah,
I will build her a
house!

(Around a 50% certainty)
If — marry— will

If I (ever) married
Sarah, I would
build her a house!

(Perhaps a 1% certainty)
If — married— would

I have a chance!

I have no chance!

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Core Idea

In English, we use different words and verb styles to express different levels of certainty or optimism about future events. This image illustrates how to convey optimism and pessimism through different grammatical structures. Let's break down these concepts with detailed explanations, examples, and relevant grammar nomenclature.

Quick reference

Optimism: High Certainty (Close to 100%)	When: Subordinating conjunction
Neutral: Moderate Certainty (Around a 50%)	If: Subordinating conjunction
Pessimism: Low Certainty (Perhaps a 1%)	If: Subordinating conjunction

Key Points

Optimism: High Certainty (Close to 100%)

Structure: When - Simple Present - will + Base Form

- Grammar Nomenclature:
- When: Subordinating conjunction
- Simple Present: Used to indicate a future event that is seen as certain
- will + Base Form: Simple future tense
- Explanation: This structure is used when we are almost certain that something will happen in the future. The use of "when" indicates a high degree of certainty, and "will" is used to indicate a future action.
- Example Sentence: When I marry Sarah, I will build her a house.
- Additional Examples: When it stops raining, we will go for a walk. When he finishes his homework, he will play video games. When they arrive, we will start the meeting.

Neutral: Moderate Certainty (Around a 50%)

Structure: If - Simple Present - will + Base Form

- Grammar Nomenclature:



- If: Subordinating conjunction
- Simple Present: Used to indicate a possible future event
- will + Base Form: Simple future tense
- Explanation: This structure is used when we think something might happen, but we are not sure. The use of "if" indicates that there is a possibility, but it is not guaranteed. "Will" is still used to indicate the future action.
- Example Sentence: If I marry Sarah, I will build her a house.
- Additional Examples: If it stops raining, we will go for a walk. If he finishes his homework, he will play video games. If they arrive, we will start the meeting.

Pessimism: Low Certainty (Perhaps a 1%)

Structure: If - Simple Past - would + Base Form

- Grammar Nomenclature:
- If: Subordinating conjunction
- Simple Past: Used to indicate a hypothetical situation
- would + Base Form: Conditional mood
- Explanation: This structure is used when we think something is very unlikely to happen. The use of "if" combined with the past tense "married" shows that it is a hypothetical situation. "Would" is used to indicate what might happen in that unlikely scenario.
- Example Sentence: If I (ever) married Sarah, I would build her a house.
- Additional Examples: If it stopped raining, we would go for a walk. (But it's unlikely to stop raining.) If he finished his homework, he would play video games. (But he probably won't finish.) If they arrived, we would start the meeting. (But we don't expect them to arrive.)

Practice with Example Sentences

To get more comfortable with these structures, let's practice with a variety of scenarios.

Scenario 1: Traveling to Japan

- High Certainty: When I travel to Japan, I will visit Kyoto.
- Moderate Certainty: If I travel to Japan, I will visit Kyoto.
- Low Certainty: If I (ever) traveled to Japan, I would visit Kyoto.

Scenario 2: Buying a New Car

- High Certainty: When I buy a new car, I will choose a hybrid model.
- Moderate Certainty: If I buy a new car, I will choose a hybrid model.



- Low Certainty: If I (ever) bought a new car, I would choose a hybrid model.

Scenario 3: Learning a New Language

- High Certainty: When I learn Spanish, I will practice every day.
- Moderate Certainty: If I learn Spanish, I will practice every day.
- Low Certainty: If I (ever) learned Spanish, I would practice every day.

Tips for Non-Native Speakers

- Identify the level of certainty: Decide how certain you are about the event happening. This will help you choose the correct structure.
- Practice with different scenarios: Create your own sentences using different levels of certainty to get familiar with these structures.
- Pay attention to verb forms: Notice the changes in verb forms when switching from high certainty (present and future forms) to low certainty (past forms and conditional).

By understanding and practicing these structures, you can more accurately express your optimism or pessimism about future events in English.



Practice Check

Answer the quiz questions below with the correct verb forms.

ITEM 01

When I _____ my homework, I will go out with friends. (complete)

Answer: _____

ITEM 02

If it _____ tomorrow, we will cancel the picnic. (rain)

Answer: _____

ITEM 03

If she _____ the test, she would be very happy. (pass)

Answer: _____

ITEM 04

When they _____, we will start the meeting. (arrive)

Answer: _____

ITEM 05

If I _____ a new car, I will choose a hybrid model. (buy)

Answer: _____

ITEM 06

If I _____ to Japan, I would visit Kyoto. (travel)

Answer: _____

ITEM 07

When he _____ his project, he will submit it. (finish)

Answer: _____

ITEM 08

If it _____ raining, we will go for a walk. (stop)

Answer: _____

ITEM 09

If she _____ the lottery, she would buy a house. (win)

Answer: _____

ITEM 10

When the sun _____, we will start our hike. (rise)

Answer: _____



ITEM 11

If I _____ Spanish, I will practice every day.
(learn)

Answer: _____

ITEM 12

If they _____ here, we would start the party. (be)

Answer: _____

ITEM 13

When she _____ home, she will call you.
(get)

Answer: _____

ITEM 14

If he _____ his job, he will travel more.
(quit)

Answer: _____

ITEM 15

If they _____ a new house, they would be very happy. (buy)

Answer: _____

ITEM 16

When we _____ enough money, we will buy a car. (save)

Answer: _____

ITEM 17

If the weather _____ good, we will go to the beach. (be)

Answer: _____

ITEM 18

If she _____ me, I would be surprised.
(call)

Answer: _____

ITEM 19

When I _____ to the store, I will buy some milk. (go)

Answer: _____

ITEM 20

If he _____ his keys, he will be late. (lose)

Answer: _____

**ITEM 21**

If I _____ rich, I would travel the world. (be)

Answer: _____

ITEM 22

When the movie _____, we will leave. (end)

Answer: _____

ITEM 23

If she _____ hard, she will succeed. (work)

Answer: _____

ITEM 24

If I _____ the president, I would make changes. (be)

Answer: _____



Self-check Answer Key

Use the key after you have completed every item on your own.

ITEM 01

When I complete my homework, I will go out with friends. (complete)

ITEM 02

If it rains tomorrow, we will cancel the picnic. (rain)

ITEM 03

If she passed the test, she would be very happy. (pass)

ITEM 04

When they arrive, we will start the meeting. (arrive)

ITEM 05

If I buy a new car, I will choose a hybrid model. (buy)

ITEM 06

If I traveled to Japan, I would visit Kyoto. (travel)

ITEM 07

When he finishes his project, he will submit it. (finish)

ITEM 08

If it stops raining, we will go for a walk. (stop)

ITEM 09

If she won the lottery, she would buy a house. (win)

ITEM 10

When the sun rises, we will start our hike. (rise)

ITEM 11

If I learn Spanish, I will practice every day. (learn)

ITEM 12

If they were here, we would start the party. (be)

ITEM 13

When she gets home, she will call you. (get)

ITEM 14

If he quits his job, he will travel more. (quit)



ITEM 15

If they bought a new house, they would be very happy. (buy)

ITEM 16

When we save enough money, we will buy a car. (save)

ITEM 17

If the weather is good, we will go to the beach. (be)

ITEM 18

If she called me, I would be surprised. (call)

ITEM 19

When I go to the store, I will buy some milk. (go)

ITEM 20

If he loses his keys, he will be late. (lose)

ITEM 21

If I were rich, I would travel the world. (be)

ITEM 22

When the movie ends, we will leave. (end)

ITEM 23

If she works hard, she will succeed. (work)

ITEM 24

If I were the president, I would make changes. (be)